Building Claude Skills

Abhijay Vuyyuru, AI Product Manager & Creator

Who I Am

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I am an **AI Product Manager** at YouTube, and an AI creator / educator. Additionally, I publish the AI Action Letter, engaging over 300K+ readers (ranked #7 globally), sharing insights on AI productivity and systems building. 1M+ community. I host AI leaders on Shortcast, a 59s AI podcast.

The Prompt Hoarder Problem

How many prompts do you have saved?

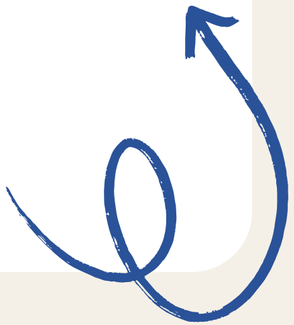
- Less than 10
- 10 to 50
- 50 to 100
- Over 100

Many users collect prompts but fail to build effective systems. This leads to repetitive tasks, limiting productivity while AI remains merely a chatbot for operators.

One Prompt's Journey

From Embarrassing to Industrial

In the next two hours, we will transform a common prompt into a powerful skill. This journey illustrates how to refine prompts for maximum productivity and effectiveness.



Live Prompt Evaluation

“Draft a good sounding reply to this email”

Common Prompt Pitfalls

Recognizing and Avoiding Mistakes

Lack of Clarity

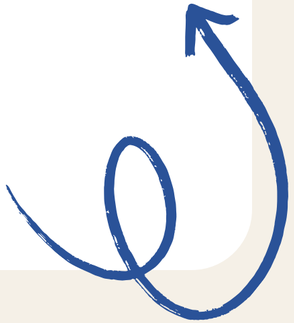
Prompts often fail due to **ambiguous language**. Clear roles and objectives guide Claude effectively, preventing misunderstandings that lead to unsatisfactory outputs.

Overgeneralization

Using broad phrases results in responses that lack **specificity**. Tailoring prompts to the context ensures more relevant and actionable replies from Claude.

Ignoring Constraints

Neglecting important **limitations** can lead to outputs that don't adhere to essential guidelines. Defining constraints is crucial for achieving desired results without unwanted surprises.

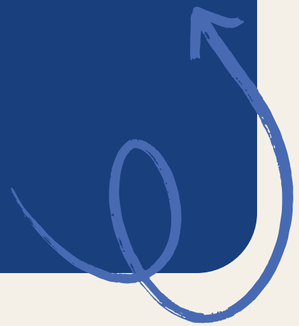


Understanding the flaws in prompt creation

Many prompts fail despite sounding good due to common pitfalls:

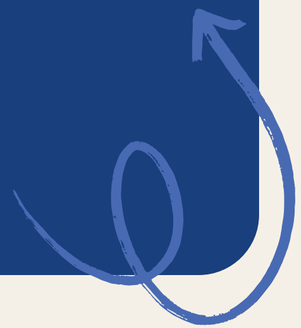
- **Lack of specificity**: Vague roles and objectives lead to generic responses.
- **Statistical average output**: AI often reflects the norm, lacking personalization.
- **Failure to define success**: Without clear expectations, outputs can disappoint.
- **Ignoring constraints**: Not setting boundaries can result in unwanted responses.

By addressing these issues, we can transform our prompts into effective tools that yield meaningful results, enhancing productivity and ensuring that AI serves our specific needs.



The Four Elements

Understanding ROLE, OBJECTIVE, SUCCESS, and CONSTRAINTS



The Four Elements

Understanding ROLE, OBJECTIVE, SUCCESS, and CONSTRAINTS

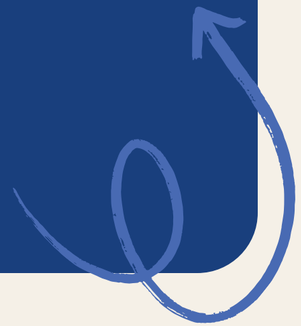
```
ROLE: You are me — a PM who replies warmly but briefly.
Answer first, pleasantries second. I sound like a person,
not a bank.

OBJECTIVE: Reply to the email below so the sender has
everything they need and no follow-up email is required.

SUCCESS: 2–4 sentences. The actual question is answered in
sentence one. If a meeting is requested, propose two
specific time windows (not "I'm flexible"). If the answer
is no, say no kindly in the first sentence. Reads like
something I'd type on my phone.

CONSTRAINTS: Never "I hope this finds you well." Never
"Just circling back." No exclamation marks. No fake maybe
when the answer is no. Do not invent facts, commitments,
or dates I didn't give you.

Here is the email:
[paste email]
```



The Power of Rewriting

Transforming Emails for Clarity and Impact

By rewriting emails, we can enhance **communication effectiveness**. Focus on clarity and brevity to convey your message, ensuring every response drives engagement and fosters collaboration.

The Inspector's Dilemma

As the operator, you constantly review outputs, but what if prompts could self-evaluate? **Automating quality checks** frees you to focus on strategic tasks rather than repetitive inspection.

Anatomy of a Loop

Key Components for Effective Systems

Objective

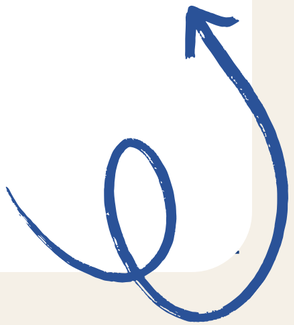
The **objective** outlines what the system must achieve, defining the purpose of the loop and guiding its functionality towards clear outcomes that enhance productivity.

Metric

The **metric** evaluates performance, measuring how well the system meets its objectives. This self-assessment ensures continuous improvement through feedback and adjustments to outputs.

Boundary

The **boundary** establishes limits for the loop, determining when it should check in with the user. This prevents runaway processes and ensures relevant outputs are prioritized.



Building a Self-Grading Loop

Automate Your Prompt Evaluation Process

Creating a **self-grading loop** transforms your prompts by integrating metrics. This approach enables Claude to evaluate its own output, ensuring efficiency and accuracy without constant human oversight.

So What Is A Loop, Really?

A prompt is a single ask, done by hand. You ask, the AI answers, you read it, you decide what's next. You're in the driver's seat for every turn.

Writing a loop means stepping out of the driver's seat and building the thing that generates those prompts for you.

Dharmesh broke a loop into three parts, and honestly it's the cleanest way I've seen it explained. Steal this framing:

1. **The objective.** What you're trying to get the system to accomplish. The end goal.
2. **The metric.** How the system itself, not just you, can tell whether a given pass came out better or worse.
3. **The boundary.** How far the loop can run on its own before it has to stop and check with you.

The Trap

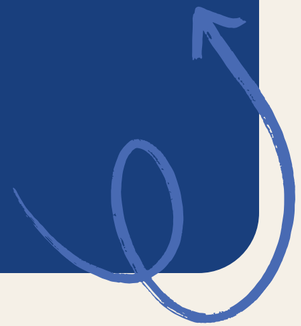
Typing masterpieces every time is unsustainable

AI Builders Embrace Autonomous Systems

In the evolving landscape of AI, leading developers have transitioned from traditional prompting to building **autonomous systems**. Key insights include:

- Boris Cherny, creator of Claude, no longer prompts directly.
- Developers are creating systems that self-prompt and evaluate.
- This shift allows for greater efficiency and innovation.

As AI continues to advance, the focus is now on **building loops** that autonomously manage tasks. This evolution is critical for maximizing productivity and fostering continuous improvement in AI workflows. Embracing these changes will revolutionize how we interact with AI and enhance operational capabilities.



95 Point QC Loop

Evaluating the Effectiveness of Prompts

Independent Evaluation

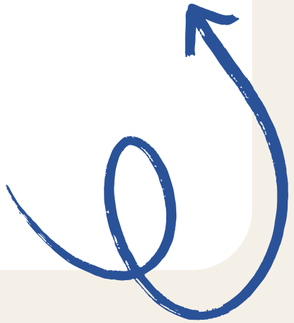
A fresh chat can assess your prompt's effectiveness, scoring it based on specific parameters, ensuring quality feedback without bias.

Continuous Improvement

Prompts can be refined through iterative evaluations, allowing you to continually enhance their performance until they meet your desired standards.

Clear Metrics

Establishing clear scoring metrics helps in objectively determining the quality of prompts, ensuring that they consistently produce high-quality outputs.



A Loop You Can Steal

LinkedIn Post Example for Skills

Objective

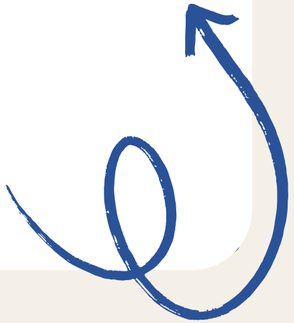
The goal is to **teach one useful idea** in under 200 words. This concise format ensures clarity and engagement for your audience.

Metric

Each draft is scored **1 to 10** based on hook, single idea, and real insight, allowing for objective evaluation and improvement of the post.

Boundary

Critique and rewrite up to **10 passes**, showcasing only the top three drafts, ensuring that your content remains focused and impactful while enhancing quality.



A Loop You Can Steal

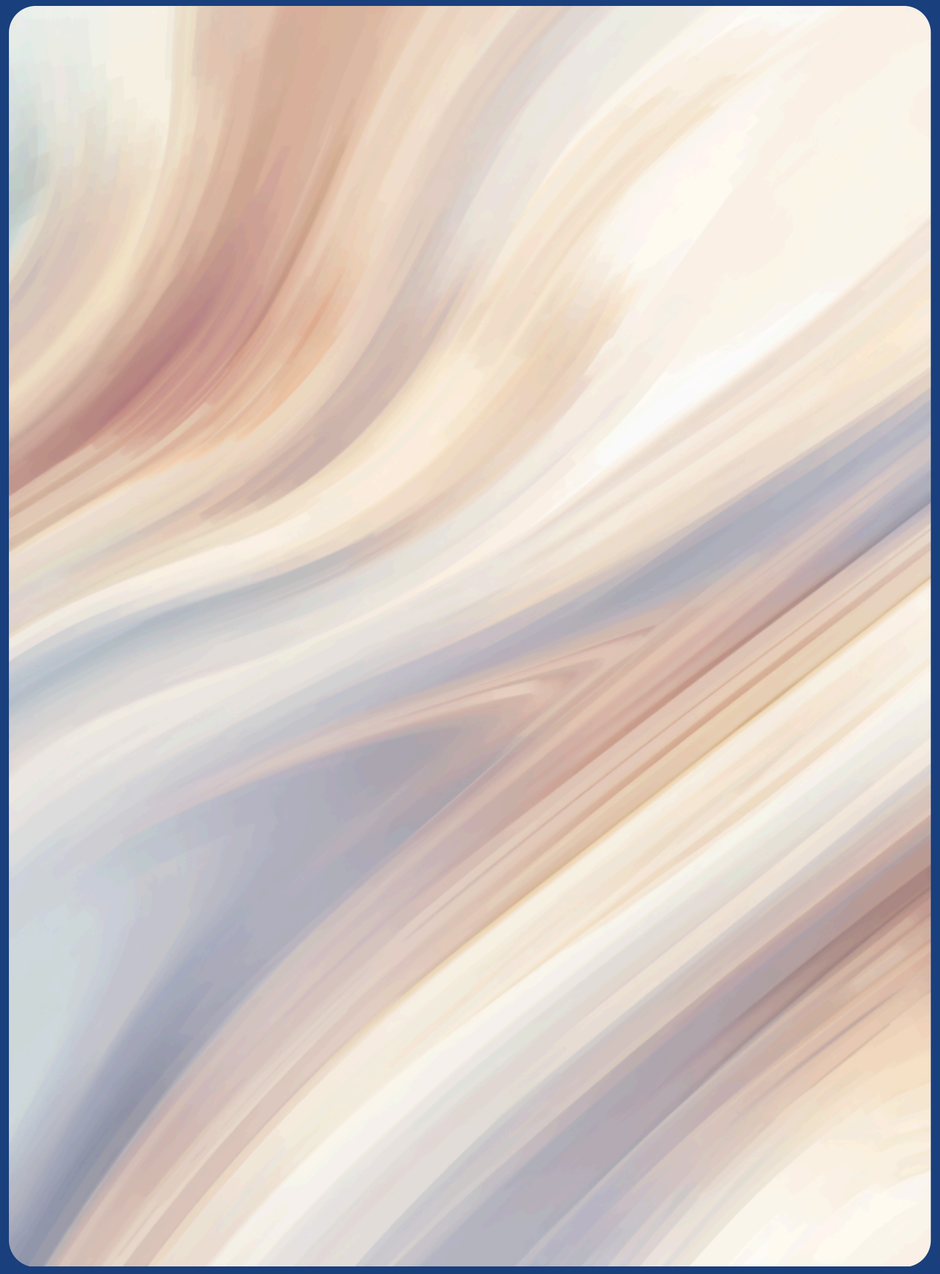
LinkedIn Post Example for Skills

```
Write a LinkedIn post about [your topic].

OBJECTIVE: teach one useful idea in under 200 words.

METRIC: after each draft, score it 1 to 10 on three things:
- Does the first line earn the click on "see more"?
- Is there exactly one clear idea (not three)?
- Would a smart reader actually learn something new?

BOUNDARY: for any score below 9, critique the draft and rewrite it.
Take up to 10 passes. Then show me only the top 3 winners.
```



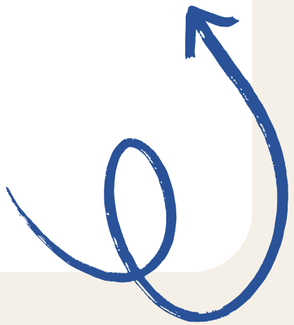
What is your most repetitive task?

- Emails
- Reports
- Scheduling
- Notes

Prompt vs. Skill

Compounding Systems for Efficiency

Transitioning from simple prompts to **self-sustaining skills** allows for greater efficiency and scalability. By establishing these systems, you can automate tasks and enhance productivity seamlessly.



Understanding Claude Skills

A **Claude Skill** is a pre-made set of instructions designed to automate tasks, allowing users to streamline workflows and enhance productivity without repetitive manual input, ensuring efficiency across various applications.

Prompt vs. Project vs. Skill

Understanding the differences between a prompt, project, and skill is essential for optimizing your productivity systems, enabling seamless workflows that enhance your work efficiency.

Which one triggers your workflow?

- Prompt
- Project
- Skill
- Task

Anatomy of a SKILL.md

Essential Elements for Effective Skills

Name

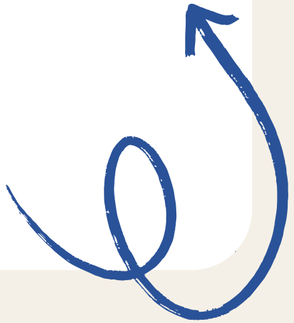
The **name** serves as the identifier for the skill, making it easy to reference and recognize within your workflow or when sharing with others.

Triggers

Triggers determine when the skill activates, enabling it to respond contextually based on specific events or commands, ensuring timely and relevant outputs in your processes.

Workflow

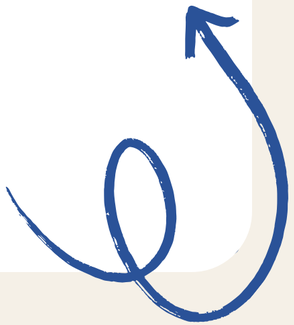
The workflow outlines the **step-by-step** actions the skill will perform, ensuring clarity and structure, and making it easy to follow for any user involved in the task.



Inbox Zero Skill

A System for Effortless Email Management

The Inbox Zero Skill automatically triages your unread emails, sorting them into categories like NEEDS REPLY and DRAFTS replies in your voice, effectively streamlining your workflow and saving time.



Setup Check

Ensure **Claude is open** and ready for use. The optional Gmail connector can enhance functionality by enabling live testing. Follow the setup steps to maximize efficiency in your workflows.

The Generator Prompt

Build Your Complete SKILL.md

Define Objectives

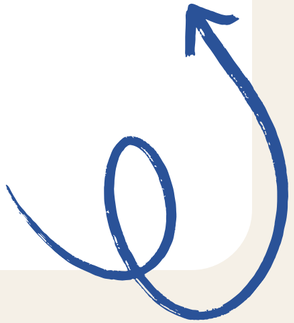
Clearly outline what you intend for Claude to accomplish with the prompt, ensuring it aligns with your productivity goals and integrates seamlessly into your workflow.

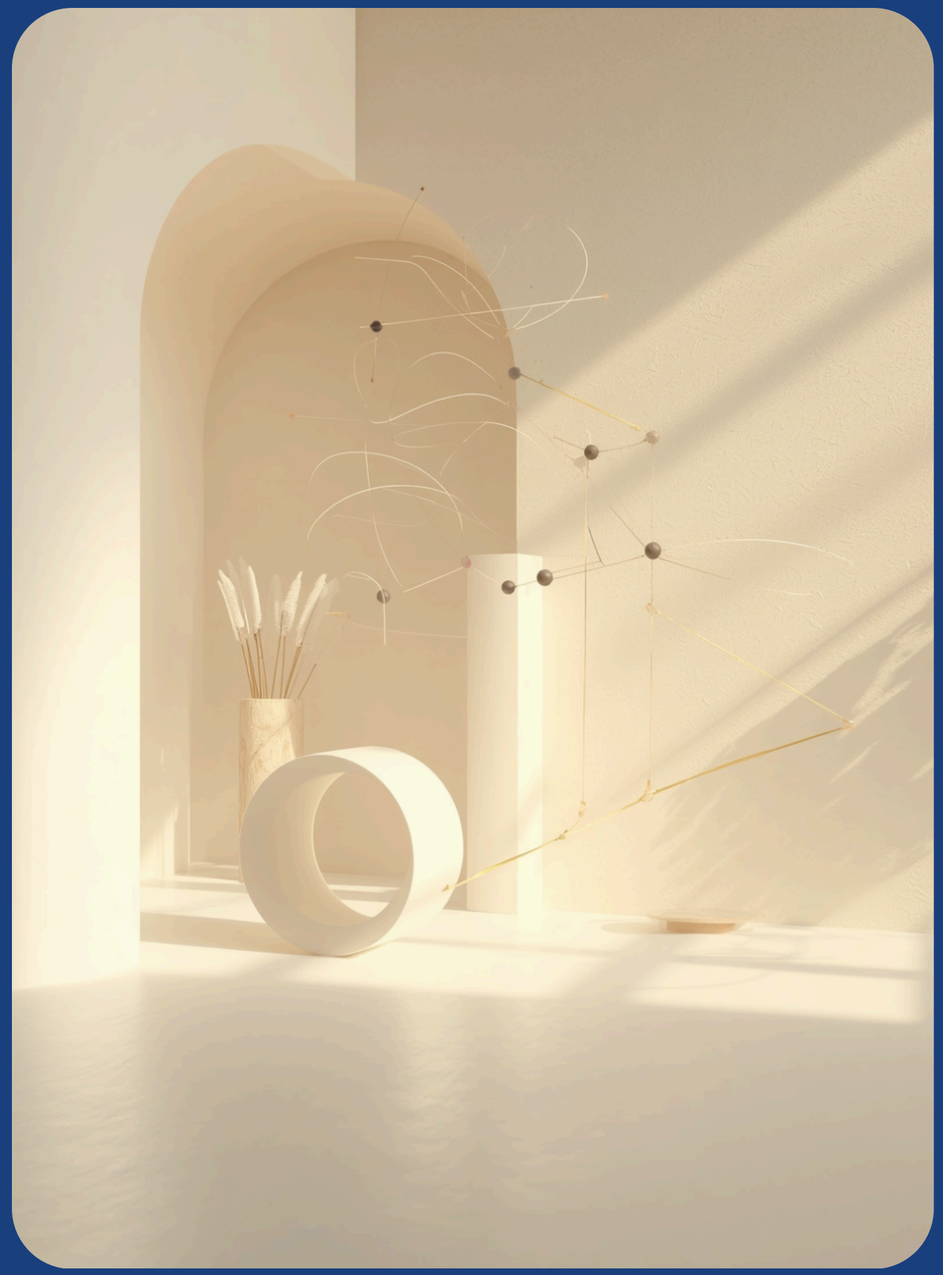
Establish Metrics

Determine how success will be measured by Claude, creating specific criteria that will guide the evaluation of outputs and improve effectiveness over time.

Set Constraints

Identify non-negotiables for the task, including what should never be included in the responses, to maintain consistency and quality in the output generated by Claude.





Generate Your Skill

Crafting a Powerful Claude Skill

Generator Prompt:
Skill.MD

In this sprint, you will learn to create your own Claude skill.

Follow the steps to generate a functional skill that enhances your productivity and automates repetitive tasks effortlessly.

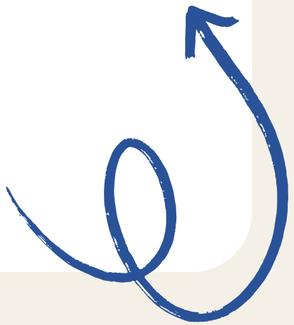
What is the first step for testing?

- Triage
- Score
- Evaluate
- Draft

Upload Your SKILL.md

Finalize and Activate Your Skill

To complete the process, upload your SKILL.md to Claude. This step transforms your setup into an operational system, streamlining your workflow and enhancing productivity seamlessly.



Choosing the Right Mode

Optimize Your Workflow with Claude

Chat

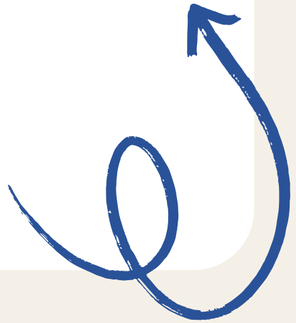
Use **Chat mode** for drafting and testing skills. This mode allows for interactive conversations, enabling quick adjustments and immediate feedback while refining your prompts with Claude.

CoWork

In **CoWork mode**, your work is organized within files. This approach helps maintain structure, allowing for collaboration on projects and efficient management of documents and resources.

Design

Utilize **Design mode** for adhering to strict brand guidelines. This mode is ideal for creating visually appealing materials with exact fonts and daily assets, ensuring consistency and quality.



My Real Stack

Leveraging Systems for Efficiency

Job Hunt OS

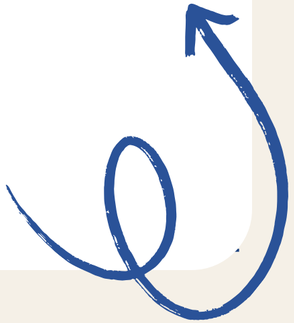
A streamlined workflow that automates job applications and outreach to potential employers, ensuring that every opportunity is maximized without unnecessary time loss.

Content Factory

This system transforms raw ideas into polished content, enabling rapid production and publication while maintaining quality and relevance in a fast-paced environment.

Chief of Staff

Hermes self -earning agent that drafts inbox replies and monitors you inbox, and is controlled via Telegram.



Chief of Staff Agent

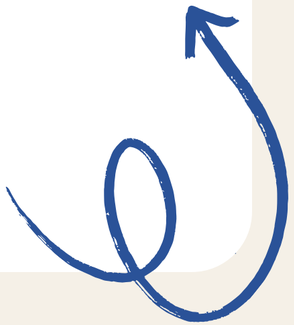
VPS + Hermes Aegnt + Skill + Telegram

Setup Guide

Your Inbox Skill

Versioning for Enhanced Efficiency

Develop your Inbox Skill iteratively, enhancing its capabilities through versioning. Each iteration builds on user feedback, creating a more refined and efficient email triage process over time.



Q&A Session

Engage with your peers during our Q&A session. Share insights and explore the most pressing skills and tasks you aim to enhance with Claude's capabilities.

What skill will you build first?

- Inbox Zero
- LinkedIn Post
- Research Scanner
- Job Hunt OS

Thank You

Building AI Skills Together